

# WC 2026 Youth Training Report

Where did World Cup 2026 starting-lineup players train between ages 5 and 16?

Data through 75 completed matches · July 5, 2026

| Completed matches | Unique starters | Unique training countries | Unique training clubs |
|-------------------|-----------------|---------------------------|-----------------------|
| 75                | 754             | 53                        | 975                   |

## Top 20 Training Countries

**Unique starters** counts each player once for every country where they trained, regardless of how long they spent there.

**Weighted starters** allocates each player as a fraction across countries in proportion to the years they spent training there between ages 5 and 16 — for example, a player who trained 8 years in France and 4 years in Spain contributes 0.67 to France and 0.33 to Spain. See Appendix 1 for the full counting rule.

| #  | Country       | Unique starters | Weighted starters |
|----|---------------|-----------------|-------------------|
| 1  | France        | 70              | 59.48             |
| 2  | England       | 49              | 36.51             |
| 3  | Netherlands   | 47              | 39.27             |
| 4  | Spain         | 38              | 27.93             |
| 5  | Germany       | 38              | 27.63             |
| 6  | United States | 31              | 21.59             |
| 7  | Belgium       | 28              | 22.78             |
| 8  | Argentina     | 26              | 20.33             |
| 9  | Portugal      | 23              | 16.80             |
| 10 | Norway        | 22              | 17.16             |
| 11 | Sweden        | 21              | 15.73             |
| 12 | Austria       | 19              | 17.08             |
| 13 | Switzerland   | 17              | 15.90             |
| 14 | Japan         | 17              | 15.35             |
| 15 | Brazil        | 17              | 15.17             |
| 16 | Australia     | 17              | 13.13             |
| 17 | Paraguay      | 17              | 10.28             |
| 18 | Uzbekistan    | 17              | 6.00              |
| 19 | Czechia       | 16              | 12.50             |
| 20 | Canada        | 16              | 12.29             |

## Top 20 Training Clubs

Same year-share method as above, applied at club level. Players who moved between clubs are split across each club in proportion to time spent there.

| #  | Club                    | Country     | Unique starters | Weighted starters |
|----|-------------------------|-------------|-----------------|-------------------|
| 1  | Anderlecht              | Belgium     | 10              | 6.11              |
| 2  | Paris Saint-Germain     | France      | 10              | 4.53              |
| 3  | Barcelona               | Spain       | 10              | 4.24              |
| 4  | Ajax                    | Netherlands | 9               | 5.59              |
| 5  | PSV                     | Netherlands | 8               | 4.90              |
| 6  | Independiente del Valle | Ecuador     | 8               | 4.07              |
| 7  | Manchester City         | England     | 8               | 3.84              |
| 8  | Bayern Munich           | Germany     | 7               | 3.81              |
| 9  | Dinamo Zagreb           | Croatia     | 7               | 3.71              |
| 10 | Benfica                 | Portugal    | 7               | 3.37              |
| 11 | Genk                    | Belgium     | 7               | 1.68              |
| 12 | Fulham                  | England     | 6               | 3.97              |
| 13 | Chelsea                 | England     | 6               | 3.49              |
| 14 | Rennes                  | France      | 6               | 3.46              |
| 15 | Lyon                    | France      | 6               | 3.09              |
| 16 | Cerro Porteño           | Paraguay    | 6               | 2.55              |
| 17 | Al Ahly                 | Egypt       | 5               | 4.00              |
| 18 | Manchester United       | England     | 5               | 3.13              |
| 19 | Hajduk Split            | Croatia     | 5               | 2.98              |
| 20 | Red Bull Salzburg       | Austria     | 5               | 2.73              |

## Local-Trained Ratio by National Team

Percentage of each team's tracked starters who spent more than 5 years training in their own country between ages 5 and 16. Sorted from highest to lowest. Players without year data are excluded from this count.

| National team | Tracked starters | Locally trained | Local ratio |
|---------------|------------------|-----------------|-------------|
| Portugal      | 14               | 14              | 100%        |
| England       | 17               | 16              | 94%         |
| France        | 15               | 13              | 87%         |
| Germany       | 13               | 11              | 85%         |
| Netherlands   | 13               | 11              | 85%         |
| Spain         | 16               | 13              | 81%         |
| Switzerland   | 16               | 13              | 81%         |
| Austria       | 15               | 12              | 80%         |
| Belgium       | 17               | 12              | 71%         |
| Sweden        | 14               | 10              | 71%         |
| Japan         | 17               | 11              | 65%         |
| Brazil        | 14               | 8               | 57%         |
| Czechia       | 18               | 10              | 56%         |
| Scotland      | 16               | 9               | 56%         |
| Argentina     | 21               | 11              | 52%         |
| Croatia       | 16               | 8               | 50%         |
| Türkiye       | 18               | 9               | 50%         |
| Canada        | 17               | 8               | 47%         |
| Egypt         | 15               | 7               | 47%         |
| Ecuador       | 13               | 6               | 46%         |
| Norway        | 21               | 8               | 38%         |
| Australia     | 17               | 5               | 29%         |
| Saudi Arabia  | 15               | 4               | 27%         |
| Paraguay      | 16               | 4               | 25%         |
| Senegal       | 16               | 4               | 25%         |
| Tunisia       | 16               | 4               | 25%         |
| New Zealand   | 13               | 3               | 23%         |
| Colombia      | 14               | 3               | 21%         |
| IR Iran       | 15               | 3               | 20%         |

|                        |    |   |     |
|------------------------|----|---|-----|
| Panama                 | 15 | 3 | 20% |
| Qatar                  | 15 | 3 | 20% |
| Bosnia and Herzegovina | 16 | 3 | 19% |
| Ghana                  | 16 | 3 | 19% |
| Uzbekistan             | 17 | 3 | 18% |
| Cabo Verde             | 18 | 3 | 17% |
| Uruguay                | 13 | 2 | 15% |
| Haiti                  | 14 | 2 | 14% |
| USA                    | 21 | 3 | 14% |
| Morocco                | 15 | 2 | 13% |
| Mexico                 | 17 | 2 | 12% |
| Côte d'Ivoire          | 15 | 1 | 7%  |
| DR Congo               | 14 | 1 | 7%  |
| Jordan                 | 14 | 1 | 7%  |
| Korea Republic         | 14 | 1 | 7%  |
| Iraq                   | 16 | 1 | 6%  |
| South Africa           | 16 | 1 | 6%  |
| Algeria                | 16 | 0 | 0%  |
| Curaçao                | 13 | 0 | 0%  |

Source: data/player\_youth\_training.csv. A player is counted as locally trained only if they spent more than 5 years training in their national team's home country (ages 5–16).

## Appendix 1 — Data Conditions and Counting Rules

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### Data sources

- **Starting XIs:** Wikipedia 2026 FIFA World Cup group and knockout-stage pages, scraped via BeautifulSoup. Each starting-XI row is linked to its match section URL.
- **Youth-club histories:** Wikipedia player infobox 'Youth career' section, fetched per player. Year spans and club names are parsed directly from the infobox table.
- **Club countries:** Inferred from each linked club's Wikipedia page lead text and categories using phrase-pattern matching.

### Age window

Only training that overlaps the age range 5–16 is included. If a Wikipedia source gives a spell of 2008–2015 for a player born in 2000, that is converted to ages 8–15 and clipped to the 5–16 window.

### Counting rule for players who moved

Each player's contribution is split across clubs and countries in proportion to the number of years they spent at each during ages 5–16. For example, a player who trained 8 years in France and 4 years in Spain contributes 0.67 to France and 0.33 to Spain. Where no year data is available, an equal split across clubs is used as a fallback.

### Confidence tiers

- **Medium:** year span extracted from Wikipedia infobox; age estimates calculated from the player's birth year.
- **Low (fallback):** only a club name was available with no year span. The club is counted in unique starters but contributes 0 to weighted starters.
- **Unresolved:** 0 players have no usable youth section on Wikipedia. They are excluded from all rankings.

### Known limitations

- The tournament was still in progress on the data collection date (2026-07-05). Knockout matches from the Round of 16 onwards are partially included.
- Club-country assignment is automated and may misclassify youth academies with ambiguous Wikipedia pages.
- Multi-country starters (102) are split across countries; multi-club starters (353) are split across clubs.
- Country backfill covers 1385 of 1385 youth-club rows. Rows without a country are excluded from country rankings only.